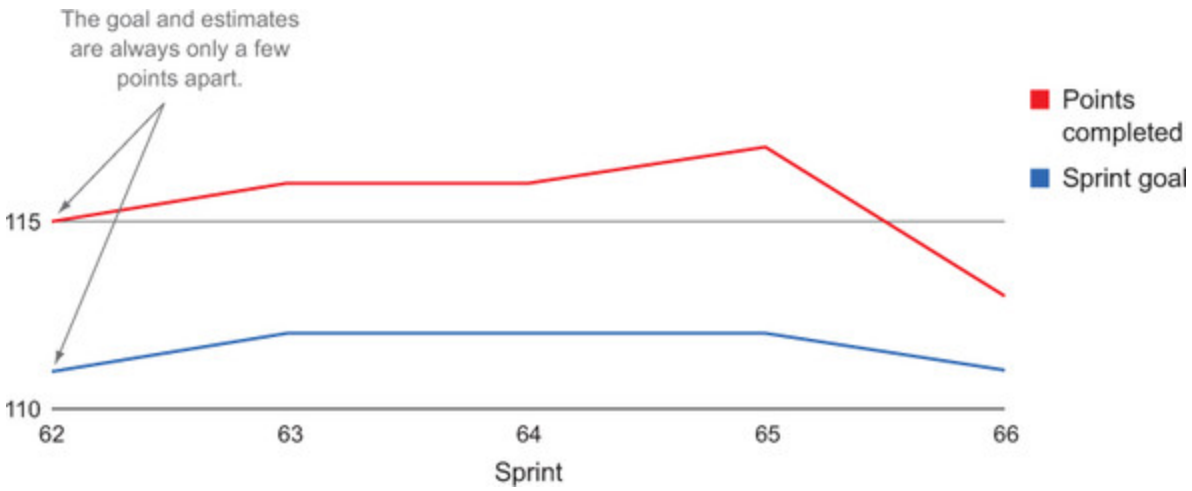


But how do you know if your estimates are any good? All you know is that you're getting done what you thought you could get done, not if you did as much as you could or if you were doing too much.

Flat-line trends occur when you see the same value over and over so your chart is just a flat line. Your team might be overestimating if you see a flat-line trend in your estimates over time, or they might be overestimating if you get done a lot more than you commit to over time. At a glance this may not seem so bad; after all, you're either being consistent or you're beating your commitments—project managers of the world rejoice! But you don't want your team to get bored, and you want to be as efficient and productive as possible; overestimating equals underachieving. As I continue, we'll add more data to help you spot potential overestimating.

It's also possible to see the same flat-line trend if your team is overestimating. If you have a team that is overestimating and you get the chart shown in figure 3.8, it could mean that your team is pushing too hard to get their work done, which is typically unsustainable. Once the trend breaks, it will result in much less work completed or people leaving the team in frustration. In this case relying on estimation to tell the whole picture could mean devastation is looming even though the trends look good.

As you can see, estimates alone can give you an idea of how your team is performing, but they can also hide things that you need your attention.